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U.S. Department of Health and Human Services
National Institutes of Health



Acai

Common Names: acai (pronounced AH-sigh-EE), acai berry, acai palm

Latin Names: *Euterpe oleracea*, *Euterpe badiocarpa*

Background

- The acai palm tree, native to tropical Central and South America and widely found in the Brazilian Amazon region, produces a round, dark purple fruit. The acai fruit, also known as acai berry, has long been an important food source for the indigenous people there, who also attribute healing powers to various parts of the plant.
- Different parts of the acai plant have been used in folk medicine for treating fever, gastrointestinal and skin conditions, and infectious diseases.
- Acai products have become popular in the United States. They have been promoted for athletic performance, high cholesterol, erectile dysfunction, obesity, aging skin, metabolic syndrome, and other conditions.
- The Federal Trade Commission has taken action against companies that marketed acai weight-loss products in allegedly deceptive ways.



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How Much Do We Know?

- Very little research has been done in people on the health effects of acai products.

What Have We Learned?

- There is not enough reliable information to say whether acai might be helpful for any health-related purpose.
- No studies in people have been published in peer-reviewed journals in the last 5 years that substantiate claims that acai promotes weight loss.

- Laboratory studies support acai's potential antioxidant and anti-inflammatory properties as well as other potentially beneficial effects. Several small studies have found that acai pulp improves antioxidant defenses in people.

What Do We Know About Safety?

- Acai pulp has been used safely for up to 3 months in clinical research. Little research has been done on the safety of acai.
- Raw acai fruit and juice can be contaminated with parasites. In rare cases, drinking the raw juice has been linked to outbreaks of the illness American trypanosomiasis (also known as Chagas disease).
- Consuming acai might affect results of magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) of the gastrointestinal tract. If you use acai products and are scheduled for an MRI, check with your health care provider.
- Preliminary research showed that taking acai may increase or decrease levels of fasting blood glucose, suggesting that acai could possibly interfere with glycemic control if taken with antidiabetes medications. If you take antidiabetes medications or any other medicine, talk with your health care provider before using acai or other herbal products; some herbs and medicines interact in harmful ways.
- Little is known about whether it's safe to use acai during pregnancy or while breastfeeding.

Keep in Mind

- Take charge of your health—talk with your health care providers about any complementary health approaches you use. Together, you can make shared, well-informed decisions.

▪ **Federal Regulation of Herbal Products**

- Depending on what's in them, how they're intended to be used, and how they're administered (orally or topically), herbal products are regulated in a variety of ways. Many herbal products intended for oral use are marketed as dietary supplements. The rules for making and distributing dietary supplements are less strict than those for drugs.
- Unlike drugs, dietary supplements are not approved by the U.S. Food and Drug Administration (FDA) before they are sold to the public. When public health concerns arise about the safety of a dietary supplement or an ingredient including an herb, the FDA can take action to protect the public. Manufacturers and distributors of supplements are responsible for evaluating the safety and labeling of their products before marketing to ensure that they meet all regulatory requirements.

For More Information

- [Using Dietary Supplements Wisely](#)
- [Know the Science: How Medications and Supplements Can Interact](#)
- [Know the Science: How To Make Sense of a Scientific Journal Article](#)

NCCIH Clearinghouse

The NCCIH Clearinghouse provides information on NCCIH and complementary and integrative health approaches, including publications and searches of Federal databases of scientific and medical literature. The Clearinghouse does not provide medical advice, treatment recommendations, or referrals to practitioners.

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Office of Dietary Supplements (ODS), National Institutes of Health (NIH)

ODS seeks to strengthen knowledge and understanding of dietary supplements by evaluating scientific information, supporting research, sharing research results, and educating the public. Its resources include publications (such as *Dietary Supplements: What You Need To Know*) and fact sheets on a variety of specific supplement ingredients and products (such as vitamin D and multivitamin/mineral supplements).

Website: <https://ods.od.nih.gov>

Email: ods@nih.gov

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